

Word family: **glass / glasses / glassy / glassware**

Base word: glass

Plural: glasses

Part of speech: mainly **noun**, also **adjective/attributive** and **verb** in narrower uses

Related forms / useful extensions:

* **glass** (n.) — 玻璃；玻璃杯；一杯；玻璃片

* **glasses** (plural n.) — 眼鏡

* **glassy** (adj.) — 玻璃般的；呆滯無神的；平滑如鏡的

* **glassware** (n.) — 玻璃器皿

* **glass door / window / bottle** — 玻璃門 / 窗 / 瓶

* **a glass of water** — 一杯水

* **pair of glasses** — 一副眼鏡

* **reading glasses** — 老花 / 閱讀眼鏡

* **safety glass** — 安全玻璃

* **magnifying glass** — 放大鏡

* **looking glass** — 鏡子 (較舊式 / 文學)

* **glass ceiling** — 玻璃天花板；無形晉升障礙

* **glass half full / half empty** — 樂觀 / 悲觀角度

Meaning in this passage

> He usually wore a plain shirt, dark trousers, and **a pair of glasses** that made him look serious at first sight.

Here, **glasses** means:

a pair of lenses in a frame worn in front of the eyes to improve vision — 眼鏡

中文翻譯：

他通常穿着簡單的恤衫、深色長褲，再配上**一副眼鏡**，令他第一眼看起來很嚴肅。

So here:

a pair of glasses = 一副眼鏡

This is a very important lexicalized plural meaning. **Glasses** here does **not** mean several drinking cups.

1. **glasses** (眼鏡) — 眼鏡

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> He wore **a pair of glasses**.

他戴着**一副眼鏡**。

Practice 2

> I can't read without my **glasses**.

我不戴**眼鏡**就看不了字。

Practice 3

> She took off her **glasses** and cleaned them.

她脫下**眼鏡**，把它們擦乾淨。

MCQ-ready definition:

glasses = 戴在眼前、由鏡片和鏡框組成，用來改善視力或保護眼睛的物品

2. **a pair of glasses** — 一副眼鏡

Because **glasses** is grammatically plural, we normally count it with **pair**.

Practice 1

> He bought a new **pair of glasses**.

他買了一**副新眼鏡**。

Practice 2

> I need another **pair of glasses** for reading.

我需要另一**副閱讀用眼鏡**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a pair of glasses = 一整副由左右兩片鏡片組成的眼鏡

3. **reading glasses — 閱讀眼鏡；老花眼鏡**

Practice 1

> He put on his **reading glasses**.

他戴上**閱讀眼鏡 / 老花眼鏡**。

Practice 2

> She keeps her **reading glasses** beside the bed.

她把**閱讀眼鏡**放在床邊。

MCQ-ready definition:

reading glasses = 幫助人看清近距離文字或物件的眼鏡

4. **glass (材料：玻璃) — 玻璃**

This is the fundamental material sense.

Practice 1

> The table is made of **glass**.

這張桌子是用**玻璃**製成的。

Practice 2

> Be careful—the broken **glass** is sharp.

小心，破碎的**玻璃**很鋒利。

MCQ-ready definition:

glass = 通常透明、堅硬但容易碎裂的材料，常用於窗、瓶、杯等

5. **glass door / window / wall — 玻璃門 / 窗 / 牆**

Here **glass** works attributively, identifying the material.

Practice 1

> He pushed open the **glass door**.

他推開了**玻璃門**。

Practice 2

> The office has large **glass walls**.

辦公室有大型**玻璃牆**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****glass + noun = 由玻璃製成的某物****

6. ****a glass (玻璃杯) — 杯 ; 玻璃杯****

A major countable noun sense.

Practice 1

> She poured water into a **glass**.

她把水倒進一隻**玻璃杯**。

Practice 2

> He dropped the **glass** on the floor.

他把**杯子**掉在地上。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a glass = 通常由玻璃製成、用來飲用液體的杯子****

7. ****a glass of something — 一杯.....****

Here ****glass**** functions as a container measure.

Practice 1

> Can I have a ****glass of water****?

可以給我**一杯水**嗎？

Practice 2

> She drank two **glasses of juice**.

她喝了**兩杯果汁**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a glass of X = 一個玻璃杯所盛載的 X 的份量****

8. ****glass (玻璃片 / 玻璃表面) — 玻璃片；玻璃面****

Practice 1

> The picture is protected by ****glass****.

那幅畫由****玻璃片****保護着。

Practice 2

> There was a crack in the ****glass****.

那塊****玻璃****有一道裂痕。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****glass = 安裝或使用在某物上的玻璃片或玻璃表面****

9. ****glassware — 玻璃器皿****

Practice 1

> The restaurant uses elegant ****glassware****.

餐廳使用很精緻的****玻璃器皿****。

Practice 2

> Please wash the ****glassware**** carefully.

請小心清洗這些****玻璃器皿****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****glassware = 玻璃製的杯、碗、容器等器皿的總稱****

10. ****magnifying glass — 放大鏡****

Practice 1

> He examined the stamp with a ****magnifying glass****.

他用****放大鏡****仔細看那張郵票。

Practice 2

> Use a ****magnifying glass**** to read the tiny print.

用****放大鏡****看那些細小文字。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****magnifying glass = 利用凸透鏡把物件影像放大的工具****

11. ****looking glass — 鏡子****

This is an older/literary expression but still recognizable.

Practice 1

> She looked at herself in the ****looking glass****.

她在****鏡子****裏看着自己。

Practice 2

> The phrase ****looking glass**** sounds old-fashioned today.

****looking glass**** 今天聽起來較古老。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****looking glass = 鏡子；較舊式或文學用語****

12. ****safety glass — 安全玻璃****

Practice 1

> Car windows are made from **safety glass**.

汽車車窗使用**安全玻璃**製造。

Practice 2

> The door uses reinforced **safety glass**.

這扇門使用強化的**安全玻璃**。

MCQ-ready definition:

safety glass = 經特別處理、破裂時較不容易造成嚴重傷害的玻璃

13. **stained glass** — 彩繪玻璃

Practice 1

> The church has beautiful **stained glass**.

教堂有很漂亮的**彩繪玻璃**。

Practice 2

> Sunlight shone through the **stained-glass windows**.

陽光透過**彩繪玻璃窗**照進來。

MCQ-ready definition:

stained glass = 由彩色玻璃組成，常形成圖案或圖像的裝飾玻璃

14. **glassy** (玻璃般光滑 / 透明的) — 玻璃般的；平滑如鏡的

Practice 1

> The lake had a **glassy surface**.

湖面**平滑如鏡**。

Practice 2

> The material has a **glassy appearance**.

這種材料有**玻璃般的外觀**。

MCQ-ready definition:

glassy = 外表像玻璃一樣平滑、閃亮或透明的

15. **glassy eyes / stare** — 呆滯無神的眼睛 / 目光

A figurative extension.

Practice 1

> He stared ahead with **glassy eyes**.

他用一雙**呆滯無神的眼睛**望着前方。

Practice 2

> She had a **glassy stare**.

她的目光顯得**呆滯空洞**。

MCQ-ready definition:

glassy eyes/stare = 眼神缺乏正常反應或情感，看起來空洞、呆滯

16. **glass ceiling** — 玻璃天花板；無形晉升障礙

A major figurative compound.

Practice 1

> She spoke about the **glass ceiling** in senior management.

她談到高層管理中的**玻璃天花板 / 無形晉升障礙**。

Practice 2

> Many employees feel that a **glass ceiling** limits their careers.

不少員工覺得有一道**看不見的晉升障礙**限制他們的職涯。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****glass ceiling = 表面看不見，但實際阻礙某些群體晉升至高層職位的制度或文化障礙****

17. ****half-full / half-empty glass — 樂觀 / 悲觀角度****

Usually in the expression:

**see the glass as half full / half empty**

Practice 1

> She always sees the ****glass as half full****.

她總是以****樂觀角度****看事情。

Practice 2

> He tends to see the ****glass as half empty****.

他傾向以****較悲觀的角度****看事情。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****see the glass as half full/empty = 對同一情況採取較樂觀 / 較悲觀的看法****

18. ****raise a glass — 舉杯祝酒****

Practice 1

> Let's ****raise a glass**** to the newly married couple.

讓我們****舉杯祝賀****這對新人。

Practice 2

> Everyone ****raised their glasses**** to the winner.

大家都****舉杯向勝出者祝酒****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****raise a glass = 舉起酒杯為某人或某事祝賀、祝福或致敬****

19. **clink glasses** — 碰杯

Practice 1

> They **clinked glasses** and celebrated.

他們**碰杯**慶祝。

Practice 2

> Everyone **clinked glasses** at midnight.

午夜時大家一起**碰杯**。

MCQ-ready definition:

clink glasses = 讓酒杯彼此輕碰，通常表示慶祝或祝酒

20. **glass something** — 裝玻璃；鑲玻璃

A narrower verb sense.

Practice 1

> The balcony was **glassed in** to keep out the wind.

露台被**裝上玻璃圍封**，以阻擋風。

Practice 2

> The old frame was carefully **glassed**.

舊框架被小心地**裝上玻璃**。

MCQ-ready definition:

glass something = 為某個開口、框架或空間安裝玻璃

21. **glass someone** — 用玻璃杯襲擊某人

This is chiefly BrE informal and should be labelled carefully.

Practice 1

> He was arrested after **glassing** a man in a bar.

他因在酒吧**用玻璃杯襲擊一名男子**而被捕。

Practice 2

> The report said the victim had been **glassed**.

報告指受害者曾遭人**以玻璃杯襲擊**。

MCQ-ready definition:

glass someone = BrE informal: 用玻璃杯或碎玻璃襲擊某人

Register: informal, violent-context usage.

Important distinction 1: **glass** vs **glasses**

This is the biggest learner trap.

glass

can mean:

* 玻璃

* 一隻玻璃杯

glasses

can mean:

* several drinking glasses

* **眼鏡**

So:

> I broke two **glasses**.

我打破了兩隻杯。

But:

> I can't find my **glasses**.

我找不到我的眼鏡。

Context decides.

Important distinction 2: **a glass vs a pair of glasses**

a glass

= 一隻玻璃杯

a pair of glasses

= 一副眼鏡

Do not say:

> **a glass**

when you mean one pair of spectacles.

Important distinction 3: **glasses is grammatically plural**

We say:

> My glasses **are** on the table.

not:

> My glasses is...

And:

> a **pair** of glasses

just like:

* trousers

* scissors

Important distinction 4: **glass** vs **cup**

glass

usually a drinking container without a handle, often made of glass.

cup

often has a handle and can be made of ceramic, paper, etc.

> a glass of water

一杯水

> a cup of tea

一杯茶

The container noun can also measure the drink.

Important distinction 5: **glass** = material vs **glass** = container

Material

> The door is made of **glass**.

門是玻璃造的。

Here **glass** is normally uncountable.

Container

> Give me a **glass**.

給我一隻玻璃杯。

Here it is countable.

This is an important countability shift.

Important distinction 6: **a glass of water** vs **water in a glass**

a glass of water

usually focuses on the quantity/containerful.

water in a glass

focuses on where the water is.

Small grammatical difference, different information focus.

Important distinction 7: **glasses vs sunglasses**

glasses

normally means spectacles, often for vision correction.

sunglasses

protect the eyes from bright sunlight.

Both are plural-form nouns, but **sunglasses** is a separate compound.

Important distinction 8: **glasses vs lenses**

glasses

the whole wearable object:

- * frame

- * lenses

lenses

the transparent optical pieces themselves.

So:

> clean your glasses

can mean clean the whole pair,

while:

> scratched lenses

specifically refers to the optical surfaces.

Important distinction 9: **glass vs crystal**

glass

ordinary glass material.

crystal

can refer to a particular high-quality decorative glass material, or to crystalline material scientifically.

A “crystal glass” in tableware contexts is not simply any ordinary glass.

Important distinction 10: **glassy vs glass**

glass

noun/material.

glassy

adjective:
= resembling glass.

> a glass surface

玻璃表面

> a glassy surface

像玻璃般平滑的表面

Very different.

Important distinction 11: **glassy eyes vs shiny eyes**

shiny eyes

may look bright, lively, tearful, etc.

glassy eyes

usually look unfocused, blank, or lacking normal responsiveness.

So **glassy** often carries a negative or concerning nuance when describing eyes.

Important distinction 12: **glass ceiling is not literal**

A **glass ceiling** usually has nothing to do with architecture.

It metaphorically represents:

an invisible barrier you can see beyond but cannot easily pass through

This is why the “glass” metaphor works.

Important distinction 13: **half-full glass metaphor**

The physical glass is literal inside the metaphor, but the full expression describes attitude:

* half full → positive/optimistic

* half empty → negative/pessimistic

So it should not be classified as a new bare-word meaning of **glass**; it is an important fixed expression built around the container sense.

Important distinction 14: **glass vs mirror**

glass

transparent material.

mirror

reflective surface used to see an image.

A mirror typically contains glass, but **glass ≠ mirror**.

The old expression **looking glass** does mean mirror, however.

Important distinction 15: **glass door vs glasses**

The plural **glasses** is especially dangerous for learners because the singular material word **glass** appears in compounds:

- > glass door
- > glass bottle
- > glass window

but:

- > glasses

very often means spectacles.

So number and construction matter enormously.

Family-extension note

Glass is an excellent polysemy family because it combines a material sense with several lexicalized countability and compound shifts:

1. **material**

- * glass
- * glass door
- * safety glass

2. **drinking container**

- * a glass
- * a glass of water

3. **eyewear**

- * glasses
- * pair of glasses

* reading glasses

4. **optical object**

* magnifying glass

* looking glass

5. **appearance**

* glassy surface

* glassy eyes

6. **figurative compounds**

* glass ceiling

* glass half full / empty

7. **verb**

* glass in an area

* BrE informal glass someone

The most important learner issue is that:

glass → glasses is not always a simple singular/plural relationship

because **glasses = 眼鏡** is lexicalized.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
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glass (material)	玻璃	transparent material	
glass door	玻璃門	made of glass	
a glass	玻璃杯	drinking container	
a glass of water	一杯水	containerful	
glasses	眼鏡	eyewear	
a pair of glasses	一副眼鏡	one complete pair	
reading glasses	閱讀 / 老花眼鏡	near-vision eyewear	
glassware	玻璃器皿	glass containers	
magnifying glass	放大鏡	magnifying lens	
looking glass	鏡子	older expression	
safety glass	安全玻璃	specially treated glass	
stained glass	彩繪玻璃	coloured decorative glass	

glassy surface	平滑如鏡的表面	glass-like	
glassy eyes	呆滯無神的眼睛	unfocused appearance	
glass ceiling	玻璃天花板；無形障礙	invisible career barrier	
glass half full	樂觀角度	positive outlook	
glass half empty	悲觀角度	negative outlook	
raise a glass	舉杯祝酒	toast	
clink glasses	碰杯	celebration	
glass something	裝上玻璃	install glass	
glass someone	用玻璃杯襲擊	BrE informal	

For your original sentence

> He usually wore a plain shirt, dark trousers, and **a pair of glasses** that made him look serious at first sight.

Here:

glasses = 眼鏡

and because the word is grammatically plural:

a pair of glasses = 一副眼鏡

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 他通常穿着簡單的恤衫、深色長褲，再戴着**一副眼鏡**，令他第一眼看起來很嚴肅。

The key learner trap here is particularly valuable:

> **a glass** = 一隻玻璃杯

> **glasses** = can mean 幾隻玻璃杯 **or** 眼鏡

> **a pair of glasses** = 一副眼鏡

So this is absolutely a worthwhile polysemy entry.